Is Eastern Happiness All the Same? Comparing Conceptions of Happiness in Taiwan, Japan, and Canada

Well-Being And Life Final Report Proposal

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Abstract

It is commonly believed that students in East Asia are less happy than their Western counterparts, as East Asian countries tend to rank lower in international happiness surveys. This report examines whether this belief holds, or whether the gap reflects different cultural conceptions of happiness rather than a genuine difference in well-being. Through a literature review, I compare Taiwan and Japan within East Asia, and contrast both with Canada as a Western case. Interviews with friends living in these countries are used to illustrate how the findings appear in everyday life.

1 Introduction

A means average, B means below average, C means can't eat dinner, D means don't go home, F means find a new family.

Above is a common joke on the Internet that ridicules the rigid standards for Asian students. Though it is only a joke, it reflects a common stereotype: Asian students experience greater academic stress than students in other regions. Since academic stress has been linked to anxiety, depression, and poor sleep among students [1], I expected that Asian students would also be less happy.

To check this idea, I looked at the World Happiness Report (WHR) 2026 [2]. At first, the ranking seems to support my expectation. The United States ranked 23rd and Canada ranked 25th, while Japan ranked 61st, China ranked 65th, and South Korea ranked 67th. However, Taiwan is an exception. It ranked 26th, almost the same as Canada, and far ahead of the other Northeast Asian countries. This suggests that Northeast Asia should not be treated as one group.

It is also interesting that the WHR 2026 found that young people in North America and Western Europe are much less happy than they were 15 years ago [3]. The report suggests that heavy social media use may be one of the reasons, but it also points out that social media alone cannot fully explain this trend.

However, the WHR ranking is based on the life evaluations of the general population, not specifically students. Moreover, the two findings above point in opposite directions. The overall ranking places Northeast Asia below North America, while young people in North America are becoming less happy. Therefore, it is unclear which pattern students would follow. If academic stress plays a major role, the gap between Northeast Asian and North American students may be even larger. If the decline among Western youth plays a major role, the gap may become smaller or even reverse.

Based on the above, in this report I want to discover whether students in Taiwan and Japan are less happy than students in Canada. Through a literature review and a small number of interviews, I also want to explore whether this gap reflects a real difference in well-being, or different cultural ideas of what happiness means.

2 Methods

2.1 Research Design

This research combines a literature review with a small number of questionnaire-based interviews. The literature review is the main source of evidence. The interviews are not meant to represent all students in each country. Instead, I use them as examples to see whether the patterns in the literature also appear in the lives of real students.

2.2 Literature Review

I first collected literature with the help of a large language model, and then checked every reference against its original source. I plan to organize the literature into three parts.

First, I review large-scale data on happiness across countries, including the World Happiness Report [2, 3] and the PISA reports on students' well-being [4]. These sources show the overall pattern, but most of them are not about university students.

Second, I review studies on the factors that may affect students' happiness. Following the mind–body–environment framework of this course, I focus on academic pressure (mind), sleep and study hours (body), and interpersonal relationships, social media, and culture (environment).

Third, I connect these studies with the lectures of this course. The lecture by Prof. Pin-Hao Chen in Week 2 and the study of [5] help me analyze students' interpersonal relationships. The lecture by Prof. Kai-Ping Yao in Week 6 guides how I measure happiness and design my questionnaire. Finally, the lecture by Prof. Po-Jang Hsieh in Week 7 provides an overall framework that I use to integrate all the factors above.

2.3 Participants

I plan to invite about 10 participants through my personal network: students living in different cities and counties in Taiwan, a Japanese friend, and a friend studying in Canada. The friend in Canada grew up in Taiwan, so her answers reflect the experience of moving between two cultures rather than that of a typical Canadian student. She will also help me invite local Canadian students so that I can do a more complete comparison.

2.4 Questionnaire

I plan to design the questionnaire into five parts. Most scales are introduced in the Week 6 lecture, and Taiwanese university student data are available for comparison.

(i) **Overall happiness:** one 0–10 question, using the same format as the World Happiness Report [2], and the Satisfaction With Life Scale [6, 7].

(ii) **Peace of mind:** the Peace of Mind scale developed by Taiwanese researchers [8]. Western scales focus on personal satisfaction, so I add this scale to capture a calmer, more balanced kind of happiness valued in East Asian cultures.

(iii) **Academic pressure:** the short version of the Fear of Failure scale [9]. Fear of failure is also measured in PISA 2018 [4], so I can compare my results with that report.

(iv) **Daily life:** weekly class hours, study hours outside class, average sleep hours, sleep quality, and daily social media use. I ask about sleep quality separately because it is more strongly related to life satisfaction than sleep hours among university students [10].

(v) **Interpersonal relationships:** two questions adapted from [5]: "Who do you turn to when something bad happens?" and "Who do you usually have fun with?"

After the questionnaire, I will hold a short follow-up interview with open-ended questions, such as "What does happiness mean to you?" and "What aspects of your life do you find meaningful?" The second question follows the survey of the Pew Research Center [11]. I will also ask about the answers that are especially high or low in the questionnaire.

Taiwanese participants will receive the Chinese version, and Canadian participants will receive the original English version. For the Japanese participant, I will use published Japanese versions if they are available; otherwise, I will note that the translation has not been validated.

2.5 Procedure

Each participant will first fill out the questionnaire online and then join a 20–30 minute interview, either in person or online. Before the interview, I will explain the purpose of this report and ask for their consent. All answers will be anonymous and used only for this report.

2.6 Analysis

Because the sample is small, I will not perform statistical tests. Instead, I will compare each participant's scores with the reference data of Taiwanese university students presented in the Week 6 lecture. Then I will group the interview answers into mind, body, and environment, place them into the Week 7 framework, and compare them with the findings in the literature.

2.7 Limitations

This research has several limitations. First, the number of participants is small, and they are all from my personal network, so the results cannot represent all students in these countries. Second, my participant in Canada grew up in Taiwan, which makes the comparison between Taiwan and Canada less clear. Third, the data I review come from different surveys with different methods and age groups, so their numbers cannot be compared directly. Fourth, all

measures are self-reported and collected at one time point, so I cannot test whether study hours, sleep, and stress cause changes in happiness. Finally, a large language model assisted my initial literature search. I checked all references manually, but some relevant studies may still be missing.

3 Expected Results

Based on the literature, I have two competing expectations. If academic pressure plays a major role, Taiwanese and Japanese students may report higher fear of failure, shorter sleep, and lower life satisfaction than Canadian students. If the decline of youth well-being in North America plays a major role, the gap may be small or even reversed.

I also expect that the answer may depend on how happiness is measured. Taiwanese and Japanese students may score lower on life satisfaction but not on peace of mind, and they may find meaning in different parts of life than Canadian students do. If this happens, it would suggest that part of the gap reflects different cultural ideas of happiness rather than a real difference in well-being.

4 AI Disclosure

Fro this part of homework(i.e. proposal), I use Large Language Model(LLM) to assist me on the following parts:

- Literature collection and integration.
- Difficult content explanation.
- Refining Writing

For the fromal research, I may use LLMs to assist me on the following parts: ()

- Literature collection and integration.
- Difficult content explanation.
- Refining Writing.
- Questionnaire design.
- Translate questionnaires into different languages.

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